

screens and virtual shopping aisles, recreates in vivid detail the interiors of big retailers. While a major newspaper detailed this high-tech studio, Kimberly-Clark wasn't the first to use a virtual shopping experience.

For more than ten years, big name brands have been turning to companies like VideoMining. Based in State College, Pennsylvania, VideoMining is the leading provider of in-store intelligence for retailers and consumer product manufacturers. They have helped clients such as Kraft, Kellogg's, Hershey Foods, Nestlé, and Clorox optimize their shopper marketing and merchandising.

Going one step further, General Mills, with their "Corner Market" in Minnesota and the Frito-Lay SMART Learning Center in Dallas, have built entire centers just for consumer behavior studies. Using the faux supermarket allows researchers to study shopping behavior in a familiar environment, that of an actual store. The store "lab" uses multiple methodologies to study the shopper's behaviors, including transaction tracking, survey research, cart tracking, manual observation, and an automated observation that includes "heat maps" that show where shoppers are spending the most time amongst the displays.

By 2010, two Food Lion lab stores were using 120 overlapping cameras to track and analyze consumers' transactions from the point of entry until their purchases. In addition to the cameras, VideoMining Corporation uses a sophisticated type of facial recognition software that can tell them exactly what age group is buying a product and what kind of display is catching their eye. Of course, shoppers in both stores are informed that cameras are observing their every move, making a skeptic like me wonder if, in fact, the